focuses on functions desired by the entire group, but particularly the four less powerful BRICS. At a formal level, their preferences are addressed by the creation of new institutions (the BRICS coordinating committee and two new multilateral financial institutions, the NDB and CRA), in which the formal rules specify their closely equivalent voice and influence with those of China. Informally, the non-Chinese BRICS seek to bind China to themselves and profit from its global rise (a dynamic discussed from the viewpoints of each country in Chapter 4). Finally, the table's bottom row highlights the functions that such a club may perform for its most powerful member or members (in this case China, potentially joined on some occasions by Russia, India, or both). The formal rules and institutional properties such as unanimous decision-making permit the intraclub hegemon—here China—to reassure its partners of its commitment to the pursuit of club goods and respect for their preferences. At the same time, the more powerful club member or members are likely to prevail when core interests are affected, as only it (or they) can pose a credible threat of exit.

PLAN OF THE BOOK

This first chapter has used insights from international relations theories and the behavior of clubs to explain the existence of the BRICS group and how it operates in the global governance system. The BRICS share common aversions to unipolarity and the hegemonic power of the G7—particularly the United States—and cooperate to promote selective common economic and geopolitical interests. The five BRICS countries have pressed for a greater voice within existing multilateral institutions, including the major international financial institutions, and more recently also have pursued their outside option of founding parallel multilateral institutions in which they themselves are in charge. With China being disproportionately strong within this club, the asymmetry of capabilities among the BRICS members has enabled China to dominate the BRICS' internal decisions, as it has the most obvious outside options vis-à-vis the BRICS, yet only to the extent that the other members continue to find value in their collaboration. In this behavior, China within the BRICS presents some echoes of the role played by the United States within the G7.

Chapter 2 goes on to evaluate several dimensions of the global power shift from the incumbent G5/G7 powers to the rising powers, particularly